

1 Rhetorical Ontology

As Heidegger was the first to identify and later adapt, Aristotle's works, particularly *On The Soul* and *Rhetoric*, posit a theory of rhetorical ontology. In *On The Soul*, Aristotle presents his answer to the question, "What is soul?" (656, 412a1, 4). As he states, "the soul must be a substance in the sense of the form of a natural body having life potentially within it" (656, 412a1, 20), and there are three kinds of substance: Matter (potentiality), Form (actuality), and a compound or complex of both. Continuing, there are different types of potentiality and actuality. So, for example, let's consider three different cases: (1) First, a child who does not speak English. (2) Second, a bilingual adult who does speak English but remains silent and/or unthinking. (3) Third, a bilingual adult speaking (or actively understanding/thinking) English.

The first case involves only potentiality: the child has the potential to know English but has no actual knowledge of such. The second involves both potentiality and the first actuality: the adult actually knows English but that actual knowledge is itself a potentiality to think or speak in English. The third case constitutes the second actuality: the adult is actually exercising their knowledge of English. The first actuality is a kind of potentiality: it is a *capacity* to engage in the activity that is the correlative second actuality. So if soul is a capacity, it is a capacity to do what? Aristotle argues that the soul is the capacity for self-nourishment, growth, decay, movement and rest (in regard to place), perception and intellect. "That is why," Aristotle concludes, "the soul is an actuality of the first kind of a natural body having life potentially within it" (656, 412a1, 27-8). Since form is what makes matter a "this", what makes matter a "chair" or a "dog", the soul is the form of a living thing: not in its shape but in its actuality. The animate behavior of living things is, therefore, causally dependent on the soul. Since the living thing is a complex of matter and form, the soul "is the actuality of a certain kind of body" (?). It is a capacity of the animate thing with a body, not the animate thing that has the capacity itself. This suggests that the soul has very little to do with individual personality or identity. In this sense, there is only soul not souls: Tom, Jeff, and Jane are different people but animated by the same (kind of) soul: by the same set of intrinsic capacities. So just like how the form of the media rhetorically encourages a specific mode of perception, the form, or soul, of the human animal influences how we see, interpret, and make sense of the world around us. It is something we all share.

According to Heidegger's interpretation, Aristotle posits that every meaningful encounter with beings concerns an event in which a human takes a being as something: as, say, a god one should venerate or as a chair on which one can sit. The element that unifies the various modes of Being is their realization of some form of present-ness or presence to the human which is expressed in the *as* of "taking-as". Their coming to be *present* as something intelligible to the human being. The chair is made intelligible to me as equipment on which I can sit. According to Heidegger's reading, *logos*, as it is found in Aristotle's *Rhetoric*, refers to more than its commonplace usage as a technical term designating an argument that attempts to persuade through logical reasoning. As Heidegger

demonstrates, it also is used to describe the human capacity which allows us to perceive, understand, and interpret our selves and our experiences in the world around us through discourse with one another. The basic function of *logos* is “to thereby make manifest” the world which is fulfilled through speaking (*Concepts* 44-5); and, it is the basic function of *logos* that reveals the rhetorical ontological nature of human being: the “basic mode in which the being of the human being as with-one-another is revealed” (45). Indeed, this is, in Heidegger’s interpretation, the fundamental character of human beings’ being in the world “in the sense of *being-as-speaking-with-one-another* through communicating, refuting, confronting” (33). The basic function of *logos*, therefore, is to make manifest the world, the objects and entities which populate it, and our relation to them. However, as Daniel Gross observes, Heidegger articulates affect, or *pathos*, “as the very condition for the possibility of rational discourse, or *logos*” (*Heidegger and Rhetoric* 4). “Broadly conceived,” Gross argues that “Aristotle’s rhetoric is the discipline that allows Heidegger to establish *logos* as a derivative mode of construing the world, a mode grounded in everyday, pathetic situations” (6).

The importance of Heidegger’s expansion of Aristotle’s rhetorical ontology lies in rhetoric’s role in determining the “*how of being*” for human beings. As the “*how of being*,” this suggests that how we perceive, understand, and communicate our environment and the objects and people which populate it is fundamentally rhetorical, but also how we make sense of our position in relation to and within our environment is also of a rhetorical nature (45). From this “*how of being*,” as Heidegger argues, “arises the manner and mode in which human beings see the world initially and for the most part, in which the world matters to human beings, in which human beings address the world” (45). From this “*how of being*” the things of the world are made intelligible in how they matter to us. The chair matters to us as equipment for sitting or, perhaps, as equipment for sitting and decoration. In this sense, as Heidegger concludes, rhetoric is the self-interpretation “*of concrete being-there, the hermeneutic of being-there itself*” (75). This suggests that the human is fundamentally a rhetorical being, and it is this rhetorical nature of the human-being that is the ontological condition which makes perception, understanding, and communication of our existence possible.

The fact that something can matter to us is grounded in our attunement; “and as a state-of-mind it has already disclosed the world-as something by which it can be threatened, for instance. Only something which is in the state-of-mind of fearing (or fearlessness) can discover that what is environmentally ready-to-hand is threatening. Dasein’s openness to the world is constituted existentially by the attunement of a state-of-mind” (*BT* 176). Thus our way of being, what Heidegger calls Dasein, is characterized as having-to-be-open: it is an intrinsic characteristic of human being (an a priori structure of our existential constitution). Just as Aristotle identified, our soul, our way of being, accounts for motion, for change and rest. What makes such motion possible is our inherent rhetorical nature, our openness to being-moved or affected by our encounters with the world and the beings which appear to us within it.

According to Heidegger’s position, *affectability* is a fundamental component

of the world and our being-in-the-world. As Dianne Davis argues, the condition for symbolic action is possible thanks to “an originary (or preoriginary) rhetoricity—an *affectability* or persuadability” (2). Indeed, affectability, or being-moved, is, as Daniel Gross states, “essential to all” (13). It is the one thing that we all share, including human and non-human agents, objects, and environments. Thomas Rickert argues that this inherent worldly affectability is “the conditions of possibility for rhetoric’s emergence” (159): it is the ontological condition required for rhetoric to emerge at all. If we recall my earlier example, just as the child has the potential to learn English, so too do all beings have the potential to move and be-moved. Our rhetorical soul is what allows us to recognize and actualize potentialities. In other words, without worldly affectability, the possibility to be-moved, to be-affected, to be-persuaded simply would not be possible. This suggests that rhetoric, in and of itself, is ontological in that rhetoric actualizes worldly affectability common to all environments, objects, and entities. It is thus from the rhetorical ontological nature of human being that our encounters within the world has the potential to fundamentally alter our being-in-the-world. Heidegger argues that our being emplaced in the world is disclosed to us in “our mood, our Being-attuned” (172). “*The mood has already disclosed, in every case, Being-in-the-world as a whole, and makes it possible first of all to direct oneself towards something*” (176); as such, we are always in one mood or another, we can never be free of moods which lie outside our subjective control. According to Heidegger, attunement, or mood, “*implies a disclosive submission to the world, out of which we can encounter something that matters to us*” (BT 177).

What Thomas Rickert’s “ambient rhetoric” emphasizes is the inextricable role that our informational and material environment plays in shaping our being-in-the-world (3): in shaping how the world is revealed to us. Rickert’s understanding highlights the rhetoricity of place and how our emplacement within particular environs fundamentally influences all human knowing and doing. As he defines it, “First, ambience is what surrounds us as material, spatial, and environmental. Second, it conveys our affective investment and emplacement within an environ. Third, ambience itself has a kind of agency, or more precisely, ambience connotes the dispersal and diffusion of agency” (16). Ambience, Rickert argues, attunes us to the “as-a-whole” (106); it is rhetorical in that it affectively discloses to us the conditions of possibility for action that we recognize in any given situation. Following Rickert’s conception, disclosure here is an attuning: “the manner in which a being finds itself fittingly or just as likely discomfittingly placed in the world, with the world being integral to and inseparable from that finding” (281). In other words, the felt response from ambience’s affective disclosure, or attunement, is either one of fittingness or discomfittingness. We feel either in-tune or out-of-tune with our environment.

For example, in the PhD orientation I attended when first beginning here at UCI, the speaker mentioned a very common occurrence among newly enrolled students, affectionately known as “imposter syndrome.” Being located in a prestigious institution, surrounded by renowned scholars, perhaps less “qualified” than others in our cohort, there is a common felt response that one does not

belong, that one is out-of-tune with this specific environment. This state of attunement then reveals certain possibilities for action while masking others: thus if one is out-of-tune, they may be less likely to offer their opinions during a seminar. However, as time goes on, we hopefully come to feel as if we are in-tune, and that attunement will disclose possibilities for action that were previously hidden to us. It is, therefore, our inherent affectability, our capacity to be-moved, on which the phenomenon of mood or attunement ontologically depends.

A brief example should help here. This is likely something that many if not all of us have experienced at some point. Let's say that we are walking through an unfamiliar city, and happen to turn into an alley. After a short distance in we are immediately overcome by a feeling of anxiety. Something about our position within this specific environmental situation produces a mood for which we cannot consciously point to the cause. As Rickert argues, "ambience is rhetorical to the extent that we become a furtherance of or site for rhetorical activity" (120): if it moves us to actualize one potentiality. Returning to our alleyway, our anxious mood comes over us entirely outside of conscious control. It is the result of the respective environment ambiently attuning us to an ensemble of elements the specificity of which need not come to conscious attention. We feel anxious, out-of-tune, without being able to pinpoint the source of that feeling to any single entity in our view. For if we could put our finger on the specific source our mood of anxiety would likely shift to fear.

For Heidegger, our affectability and subsequent moods are aspects of what it means to exist in the world. Thus, mood "comes neither from 'outside' nor from 'inside', but arises out of Being-in-the-world, as a way of such being" (BT 176). Considering that moods are outside of subjective control, there is something about fundamental experience of our position within and relation to the world around us that is outside of our conscious control. This suggests that some part of mood has an external ground: moods are a derivation of our being-attuned within a specific environment. The fact that we feel out-of-tune with our position within this alleyway reveals the important role the world plays in our being-in-the-world. For if we were not constantly being-attuned by our environment then the anxious mood which overcomes us would simply not be possible. We would be unable to respond to the perceived and/or unperceived variations which take place throughout all environments. Attunement, therefore, results from feedback, from the actualization of mutual affectability between the human and their specific environment. Or, as Rickert puts it, attunement results "from the co-responsive and inclusive interaction that brings out both *immersion* (being-with) and *specificity* (the way of our being there)" (my emphasis). Attunement, in this sense, "conveys the countless modalities of responsiveness to this affectability" (8-9). It is our attunement or mood which makes known what is of relevance in the world around us, it makes possible the ability to orient ourselves toward one particular affordance of our environment.

Accordingly, our anxious mood attunes us to certain potentialities for action while masking others. Our anxiety may disclose the route ahead of us leading deeper into the ominous alleyway as dangerous or unpassable, while highlighting

the path behind us as safe or as an escape route. Our attunement influences how our environment and the entities within it are made present to us in the moment. In how they matter to us. “For nature,” Aristotle posits, “like thought, always does whatever it does for the sake of something, which something is its end.... That for the sake of which has two senses, viz. the end to achieve which, and the being in whose interest, anything is or is done” (415b1, 20-25). As such, this suggests that how we understand the potentialities an environment affords and the potentiality we choose to actualize in any given situation is fundamentally structured around that “for-the-sake-of-which”. Thus, once again back in our ominous alleyway, I may retreat for-the-sake-of remaining unharmed, or I may choose to continue forward despite my unease for-the-sake-of not missing the last bus back to my hotel. In any particular instance, our mood attunes our for-the-sake-of-which, the structural grounds on which we understand and actualize any potentiality according to our interest in which anything is or is done. If we take our existence as being present in a specific environment, then we necessarily understand our existence as open to being affected by that environment; we understand the environment and beings which populate it as having the power to affect our for-the-sake-of-which. Therefore, the phenomenon of presence, how our own present-ness and the present-ness of other beings is disclosed to us is, the presence we feel when immersed in an environment virtual or physically real is, at its core, an ontological concern. This suggests that rhetoric itself is ontologically derived from worldly affectability, and, thus, has the power to transform our *specificity* (the way of our being-there or how we inhabit the world) through ambient attunement as affective disclosure.

2 Rhetorical Phantasia

Let us now turn to Aristotelian opinion, or *doxa*, and the faculty of the soul which makes it possible: *phantasia*. According to Aristotle, one element of this faculty, “but sometimes by means of the images or thoughts which are within the soul, just as if it were seeing, it calculates and deliberates what is to come by reference to what is present; and when it makes a pronouncement, as in the case of sensation it pronounces the object to be pleasant or painful, in this case it avoids or pursues; and so generally in cases of action” (431b). *Phantasia*, provides the mental images by which the human is able to think and deliberate. The images summoned to the mind by *phantasia* have their origin in direct sensation or perception (*aisthēsis*). *Phantasia* is activated “when we do not perceive distinctly” (*De Anima* 428a), it supplies what is missing when the object cannot be perceived or when it is not definitively perceptible. To use Aristotle’s example, *phantasia* is active when we see a hazy figure in the distance and come to the opinion that it is a man.

While *phantasia* may lie within our conscious control whenever we wish (when we recall a specific memory or image, say, in the use of mnemonics), at least one aspect of phantasia functions outside of our conscious control. For when we are looking at the hazy figure in the distance, our opinion is not arrived

at through deliberative speculation. We, in the moment, do not specifically call up a similar experience that happened two years prior when we viewed a hazy figure in the distance and it turned out to be a man. Rather, *phantasia* draws from our backlog of experiences to unconsciously fill in the gaps; it serves to rhetorically mediate images of the “future in view of the present” and past (428b). Our opinion may be true or false, as we may approach the figure to find out it was actually a tree; but *phantasia* is the faculty which makes opinion formation possible by mediating direct perception with our experiential backlog.

In calling *phantasia* “an affection [*pathos*] which lies in our power whenever we choose,” Aristotle differentiates *phantasmatic* formation from the formation of opinion which is not subject to our individual will: rather, “when we think something to be fearful or threatening, emotion is immediately produced, and so too with what inspires courage” (427b). To *phantasize*, Aristotle concludes later, “is to form an opinion exactly corresponding to a direct perception” (428b). That opinion is not subject to conscious will is derived from, Ned O’Gorman argues, “opinion’s external grounding—we form opinions about the world about us, and the world about us forms our opinions.... Through *phantasia*, opinion makes judgments about the world of appearances” (25). Thus, while *phantasia* lies within our conscious control, “in forming opinions we are not free: we cannot escape the alternative of falsehood or truth” (427b). As what makes deliberative and speculative thinking possible, *phantasia*, ontologically speaking, is the faculty which makes opinion, understanding, and knowledge possible; therefore, it is the faculty which enables *logos*. However, there is another connection that needs to be made here. Aristotle suggests that *phantasia* is “some kind of movement” (*De Anima* 428b), and by further describing *phantasia* as an “affection” (*pathos*) he connects the movement produced by *phantasia* with that produced by affect or *pathos*. As he defines them in the *Rhetoric*, “[t]he emotions are all those feelings that so change men as to affect their judgements, and that are also attended by pain or pleasure. Such are anger, pity, fear and the like, with their opposites” (1378a 21-23). “For all living things,” as he states in *Movement of Animals*, “both move and are moved for the sake of something, so that this is the limit of all their movement—that for the sake of which” (6.13-16). As he continues, “the living creature is moved by intellect, imagination, purpose, wish, and appetite” all of which, barring intellect, are reducible to desire (6.16-24). Accordingly, Aristotle posits that we must “admit to the full that being pained or pleased, or thinking are movements (each of them a being moved), and that the movement is originated by the soul” (*De Anima* I. 4.5-7; my emphasis). “Sensation depends,” Aristotle concludes, “on a process of movement or affection from without, for it is held to be some sort of change in quality” (663, 416b1 33-4). It is for this reason that affect is originated *by the soul*, not *in* the soul, and always in response to the direct perception of a sensible object.

If Aristotle is correct and pleasure is the sensation of a particular emotion, and if “imagination is a weakened sensation, then both the man who remembers and the man who hopes will be attended by an imagination of what he remembers or hopes” (*Rhet.* 1370a; I.xi.6; 117; my emphasis). A crucial implication in this notion is the temporal range available to *phantasia*; for to remember is

to bring images of *past* events, objects, persons, and scenes before the eyes in the *present*, while to hope or fear is to project potential images into the *future* based off the *present* situation. Indeed, it is the capacity of *phantasia* to encompass and incorporate *phantasmata* of the past, present, and future which generates the driving *pathetic* force that works to shape opinion and thereby lead to judgement.

Since all the images available to be summoned by *phantasia* as well as all felt sensation or affect have their origin in direct perception of sensible things, then affect and intellect are movements originated by the soul in direct response to our encounters with the world and the other beings and objects that populate it. The very possibility to experience an affectual response is dependent on the *phantasmatic* faculty of the soul. This is most clearly illustrated in Aristotle's definition of fear in the *Rhetoric*: "[f]ear may be defined as a pain or disturbance due to *imagining* some destructive or painful evil in the future" (1382a 22-23; my emphasis). As Aristotle states, "action is prompted by desire" (Soul 433a); or as he states elsewhere, "[t]he organic parts are suitably prepared by the affections, these again by desire, and desire by imagination" (*Movement* 702a 15-21). *Phantasia*, therefore, is fundamentally involved in every action in that it is the faculty which enables us to experience an appearance, the faculty by which our presence and the presence of other beings in our environment is made intelligible to us in terms of our for-the-sake-of-which.

Before moving forward, let us recap the primary points made thus far. The soul, as an intrinsic capacity of living beings which accounts for the various types of movement of which they are capable is what makes us what we are; and the primary characteristic of such is openness, the capability to move and be-moved, the inherent affectability found in all living things. *Phantasia* is a faculty of the soul that mediates direct perception of sensible things, enables mood formation, and enables *logos*: through which opinion formation is possible and which makes intelligible the potentialities afforded by our environment in terms of our for-the-sake-of-which. Both mood and opinion are movements originated by the soul in direct response to sensible objects and serve to attune us to our environment in a certain way. For if we come to the opinion that Aristotle's hazy figure in the distance is a bear or wolf, our orientation to that figure will be far different than if we opine that it is merely a tree. Either way, both our affectual and intellectual responses will reveal some possibilities for action while masking others by directly influencing our for-the-sake-of-which.

This suggests that each moment of a human's existence constitutes an event where the person "chooses" a way to be; consciously or not, they may choose to unthinkingly continue in the previous way of being or they may choose a different path. In each moment we must choose to actualize one of the many potentialities that are present in that moment. Insofar as I act on one of these potentialities, I necessarily do not act on others; and, by actualizing one potentiality within the total range of all possible potentialities, I am choosing a way to Be. Just as a speed bump is rhetorical in that it attempts to move or persuade us to slow down by orienting our for-the-sake-of-which—for the sake of not damaging our car—so too is the fallen tree blocking the trail on which we hike rhetorical in that

it moves or persuades us to climb over the obstacle for-the-sake-of reaching the mountain's summit.

Rhetoric, therefore, actualizes mutual affectability: For, as Aristotle argues, “[e]verything that is acted upon or moved is acted upon by an agent which is actually at work” (664, 417b1, 17). The feedback that results between the mover and the moved is, then, the ontological manifestation of this actualization of mutual affectability. Rhetoric discloses the potentialities we recognize and moves us to actualize a potentiality that is made intelligible to us through attuning our affectual and intellectual responses which, in turn, attunes our for-the-sake-of-which by revealing the world in a certain way, by shaping the potentialities we understand as available for actualization in the moment. In light of this, I will be adopting Thomas Rickert’s definition of rhetoric with some alterations:

Rhetoric is a mutually affectable “*way of revealing the world for others, responding to and put forth through affective, symbolic, and material means*” which influences our affectual and intellectual responses that make present some potentialities while masking others, “*so as to (at least potentially) reattune or otherwise transform how others inhabit the world to an extent that calls for*” the actualization of some potentiality “(which can include, of course, steadfastness, refusal, or even apathy)” (162).

3 Rhetorical Ecology

Now I will briefly turn to explain my understanding and definition of “environment” and “ecology” and how they function rhetorically. Aristotle, Heidegger, and Rickert’s understanding of human being existing within inescapable environmental relationships works to further break down the dichotomy between natural and artificial environments by figuring environment as the total network of involvements within which all possibilities for affect, thought, and action originate. This groundwork helps us understand how our existence and the existence of all other entities within a specific environment are constituted by their involvements within what I call an “ecological network of mutual affectability”: or a rhetorical ecology. The work of Sarah Ahmed extends this to demonstrate how a built environment is inflected with various ideologies and political implications which are not only shaped by the bodies that built them, but also shape, in turn, the bodies that occupy them. This understanding of a built environment as, what Ahmed calls, an “orientation device” illuminates Jenny Edbauer’s argument that our practical conscious does not exist outside the interconnection of forces, rhetorics, moods, and environmental, social, and political histories that cohere around material spaces and physical locations. Rather, the range of our moods, thoughts, expressions, and discourses is shaped by our dynamic rhetorical ecology: the concatenation of and interaction with other objects, entities, peoples, discourses, material environments, social norms, and economic and governmental institutions and policies.

Accordingly, I will define “environment” as a specific bounded location wherein feedback between various entities is actualized. Furthermore, because circulation between different environments can take place, I believe it is better to consider the rhetorical force exerted by environments along ecological lines. As such, I use “rhetorical ecology” to describe the overall ambient array of elements and the relations between them that constitutes a respective place as *place*. For the notion of rhetorical ecology acknowledges the distribution or diffusion of agency within an environment and across the various objects and entities which populate it, all of which comes together to form the ambient backdrop that enables human being insofar as we are shaped by and take shape within environs. What an understanding of rhetorical ecologies discloses or opens to us is a dynamic, interrelated, and co-responsive world of mutual affectability which does not outright control or predetermine our experiences and understanding, but rather rhetorically attunes us to the affective and symbolic ground from which mood, consciousness, lived experience, and willed activity derives. Reality, from this perspective, is not constituted by any individual or nonhuman actor; instead, it is the perception, the resulting interpretation of nonhuman, human, material, conceptual, and semiotic entities existing within a dynamic entanglement of mutual affectability. “This ensemble of elements” and entities which constitute a specific rhetorical ecology, as Rickert argues, “forms a material-social-hermeneutic ecology” that is always ambiently attuning us in our daily existence (272).

Let’s say two middle-aged men are hiking in the San Gabriel Mountains of Southern California. One man was born and raised in Southern California; the other is a recent immigrant who grew up in Ireland. As these two men are hiking along the trail, they hear an unidentifiable sound from somewhere in front of them. Let’s say this sound has no visible source and was not distinctly identified by either man on first experiencing it. In response to this environmental stimulus via our affectability a mood is immediately formed in each respective man. The SoCal resident experiences a deep-seated anxiety. This mood may cause him to instinctively freeze and move him to search for the source of said anxiety. This mood orients his attention to elements of the environment he previously ignored, such as the shrubbery on the side of the trail or the contours between the various rocks. Then the sound occurs again. Having been oriented towards identifying this sound and its source, the noise is more clearly heard and, influenced by his anxiety, the man comes to the opinion that it is the telltale sound of a rattlesnake. He has yet to definitively see the snake, and so his opinion may be true or false, but in the moment of opinion formation it is believed to be true: for, as Aristotle states ‘no one thinks that he has an opinion when he thinks that an object of his thought is capable of being other than it is’ (??). This opinion then causes his mood to shift from one of anxiety to one of fear. The path in front of him may now afford no possibility for moving forward in fear of being bitten; whereas the trail behind him now affords the possibility of an escape route from his currently threatening situation.

Now let’s turn to the Irishman. Having never had any previous experience with snakes in his lifetime, hearing the sound for the first time will likely generate

a mood of curiosity. This mood allows for various orientations towards his environment. He begins to look around for whatever creature or object has made this unidentifiable sound. On hearing the sound the second time more distinctly, let's say he comes to the opinion that it is some weird kind of beetle he has never encountered before. Thus, his curious mood persists and the path forward now affords the possibility for fascinating discovery. His attention may similarly be directed towards elements of this scene that were previously passed over such as the various trees or other flora and fauna populating the area. In this example, the same direct perception is experienced by each man, but their resulting mood and opinion vary dramatically. This suggests that the formation of both mood and opinion are environmentally and culturally conditioned by the respective rhetorical ecologies within which they have been *attuned*. In this case, our affective response (our mood) and our intellectual response (our opinion) are determined by having been fundamentally attuned by our experiences within certain environments over time. Mood and opinion are influenced by the backlog of past experiences within specific environments. Thus, in the moment, our mood and opinion are determined by our experiences of various environments in the past which conditions our experience of the current environmental situation we find ourselves in.

As I mentioned earlier, all environments exert an inescapable force which rhetorically attunes the human beings within it. After spending enough time being-attuned in such a way, the human being comes to be rhetorically *in-tune* with their environment: they will be able to perceive possibilities for meaning making and action that escape others who are fundamentally *out-of-tune*. Our attunement and subsequent mood is what makes certain environmental affordances available to some while masking them from others. This is why the SoCal resident and the Irishman experience such dramatically different moods and form different opinions in response to hearing the "rattlesnake." This suggests that our uncontrollable intellectual and affectual responses (opinion and mood) are fundamentally derived from our having-been-attuned by specific environments over a period of time. Where the SoCal resident has spent enough time being attuned to become *in-tune*, the Irishman has not and is fundamentally *out-of-tune*.

4 Virtual Environments

A virtual environment is a computer-generated world, oftentimes interactive and consisting of scenes, landscapes, flora, fauna, and other objects. What needs to be emphasized here is that an effective virtual environment is, first and foremost, a *rhetorical ecology*. The persuasiveness of virtual environments depends on how it constructs and presents itself as an ecology: how it manifests the relations of the virtual objects and creatures to one another and their environment, and to the player as well. The ontological status of virtual environments and the objects and entities within it need not refer to any factual, objectively real object or environment; rather, VEs ability to immerse the players and exert rhetorical

powers requires that the player be thrown into a persuasive situational reality: an ecological relationship of mutual affectability wherein the environment—and the objects and entities which populate it—appears to act on and respond to the player as much as the player is able to act on and respond to them.

In order to understand how a virtual event in a digital game is rhetorical, we have to understand the way in which the ensemble of game elements is constructed to affect or transform how we inhabit that space—and/or others—by rhetorically shaping our immediate affectual responses or mood, and our intellectual responses or opinion through our interactions with the game world. These elements, as Calleja observes, are “the human player, the representational sign, the structural properties of game and environment, and the material medium which instantiates the combination of these elements” (11). If we consider my primary artifact, *Red Dead Redemption 2*, while the material medium, signs, and environmental and structural properties of which a respective VE consists remain the same, player aspects can change from person to person and culture to culture. The sociocultural baggage one brings with them to the game, the results of having been attuned within a specific rhetorical ecology over time, will influence the possibilities of action recognized by each respective player.

Because the virtual environment a player experiences, as a completed product, is essentially static and stable, all of the environmental affordances, all of the potentialities of action for the player within this virtual world are *always already* predetermined by the programmer(s) and the program. A specific virtual program will, therefore, technically allow only a specific number of actions and interactions to be made with a specific number of virtual objects and entities. Furthermore, because every virtual program has, at least implicitly, an ultimate operative goal or design in regard to the player, the task of the researcher analyzing such a virtual ecology is to make manifest the relations between the player, the virtual entities and objects that are encountered, and the VE within which the player exists and which orients them towards achieving the ultimate operative goal.

Calleja’s Player Involvement Model (PIM) provide us with an effective methodology to analyze the ensemble of game elements and player involvement which shapes the player’s experience of a specific VE and game overall. The PIM diagnoses six dimensions of involvement within two temporal phases: “the macro and the micro” (37). The PIM’s six dimensions are “*kinesthetic involvement, spatial involvement, shared involvement, narrative involvement, affective involvement, and ludic involvement*” (38). Kinesthetic Involvement “relates to all modes of avatar or game piece control in virtual environments, ranging from learning controls to the fluency of internalized movement.” This dimension requires more conscious attention when the player has yet to full master the controls or because a particular situation demands a complex sequence of actions that is challenging for the player. Spatial Involvement “concerns players’ engagement with the spatial qualities of a virtual environment in terms of spatial control, navigation, and exploration.” “It accounts for the process of internalizing game spaces that is a powerful factor in engaging players and giving them the sense that they are inhabiting a place” (43). Shared Involvement “deals with the en-

gagement derived from players' awareness of and interaction with other agents in a game environment," including human and nonhuman agents. Narrative Involvement "refers to engagement with story elements that have been written into a game as well as those that emerge from players' interaction with the game." As such, there are two interrelated aspects of this dimension: "the narrative that is scripted into the game and the narrative that is generated from the ongoing interaction with the game world, its embedded objects and inhabitants, and the events that occur there" (43-4). Affective Involvement "encompasses various forms of emotional engagement," ranging from the calmness of an aesthetically beautiful environment to the adrenaline of combat situations. "This dimension ... accounts for the rhetorical strategies of affect that are either purposefully designed into the game or precipitated by an individual player's interpretation of in-game events and interactions with other players" (44). Lastly, Ludic Involvement concerns "players' engagement with the choices made in the game and the repercussions of those choices" (43-44). "These choices can be directed toward a goal stipulated by the game, established by a player, or decided by a community of players" (44).

If you turn your attention to the infographic, The outer edge of each triangular segment in the model represents full attentional resources directed toward that dimension of involvement. In this state, players will be attending primarily to that one dimension. The narrowing triangles of each dimension in the micro phase represent a process of internalization, where a move toward the center requires incrementally less attentional resources directed toward that dimension of involvement.

5 Analysis (Need to tie in *phantasia*. Since it is left implicit, *phantasia* fills in the gaps. Thus a younger child with no knowledge of the implied content would likely not come to the same interpretation as an adult)

Turning to my primary artifact, Rockstar's *RDR2*, I believe one specific event can help demonstrate the benefits of Calleja's PIM when more thoroughly informed by rhetorical ecology and ontology. I have selected this game as my primary artifact because it features one of the most robust, immersive, and realistic virtual ecologies I have ever encountered. Here I would like to pause to mention that this event contains implicit sexual assault and, though nothing is definitively shown, it can still be quite disturbing. So please feel free to leave if you are uncomfortable with such material. Arguably one of if not the most controversial event that occurs in *Red Dead Redemption 2* is a scene wherein the game's protagonist, Arthur Morgan, is implicitly raped by a man named Sonny who lives near Lakay in the swamp section of the map. Lakay is located near Saint Denis, a city the player, if they are following the main narrative arc, won't

reach until the second half of the game. Given this location, it is likely that the player will have spent enough time playing to have mastered, or internalized, the controls for movement (*kinesthetic involvement*). Having mastered this dimension, the player's conscious attention will be directed to other dimensions of the model. And, as Calleja notes, once a player has mastered the controls, it becomes possible for the player to cognitively interpret the actions of the avatar as *their own* (68). In other words, mastering the *kinesthetic dimension* allows for a more psychologically potent identification between the player and the avatar they control. Only when the *kinesthetic dimension* has been mastered, when the controls and hardware have become, what Heidegger calls "phenomenologically transparent"—a state wherein we do not need to direct conscious attention to them to use—will one be able to feel as if they are present in the virtual world, as if they exist within the ecological network of mutual affectability the game attempts to establish.

Considering this, it is likely the player has come to feel *in-tune* in this virtual world, to feel as if they *fit*. Moreover, as the house in question is in a rather obscure location, it is highly likely that the player randomly happens upon it while searching for the various items and loot hidden throughout the world (*spatial involvement*). Their mood (*affective involvement*) may be one of curiosity leading them to explore this section of the map; it may be one of determination, if they are trying to discover hidden items or the various easter eggs strewn throughout the world. Indeed, part of what makes such a complex open world game like *RDR2* so appealing is the ability to search and discover. However, what one discovers might not always be something positive, and this element of surprise embedded in the *spatial dimension* amplifies the player's affective response (*affective dimension*).

Add video clip

As the video demonstrates, upon approaching the home the player is hailed by Sonny and invited in to see his skull collection (*shared involvement*). Interestingly, when I first discovered this event, Sonny invited you in with the promise of food. So at some point since 2019, Rockstar's developers have changed that to what it now is. In my opinion, this is likely due to the fact that food is so prevalent in the world that it may not have been enticing enough to the players. If you choose to accept the invitation (*ludic involvement*), as soon as the avatar crosses the door's threshold a cutscene is triggered (*narrative involvement*) that the player is unable to skip. Accordingly, this directs the player's attention more so to the *narrative, shared, and affective dimensions*, while the *spatial and kinesthetic dimension* fade into the background once the player realizes they have lost control of their avatar. This cutscene depicts the swamp man clubbing Arthur over the head, resulting in the player's "vision" becoming distorted and slowly fading to black to simulate unconsciousness. However, before unconsciousness happens, the player hears what sounds like a belt buckle being fiddled with and the swamp man referring to Arthur as "my pet." Additionally, he states, "You struggled. You struggled and lost," and "Friendship ain't so tough, and neither are you." After Arthur loses consciousness you hear the sound of a body being dumped, and the cutscene ends to find that you have been relocated with your

health, stamina, and deadeye cores¹ being depleted and having had one dollar stolen. Lastly, his first few bow-legged steps seem indicative of what would be referred to in a different situation as “saddle soreness.” While one would expect health and stamina to be drained after such an event, the fact that the deadeye core is drained suggests a disruption in Arthur’s psychological state. Additionally, after this event, while at camp Bill Williamson approached Arthur and mentions how he met a man in a swamp who knew all about Arthur. His tone and diction further indicate that Arthur is raped. From this dialogue along with other context clues like Williamson being dishonorably discharged from the U.S. army for attempted murder and deviancy and some innocuous comments made by other characters, it is likely that Williamson is gay. How or why he knows Sonny is never disclosed.

Once the player has recovered control of the avatar they are free to return to the swamp man’s house and enact vengeance or simply ignore it and move on (*ludic involvement*). This event likely produces a mood of disgust, outrage, or anger; thus, many players will return to kill the swamp man in a variety of ways: some simply shoot the offender while others have hog tied him and proceeded to feed him to the alligators commonly found throughout the swamp. This shows that the mood or affective response resulting from this event discloses some conditions of possibility while masking others. Those who suffered profound emotional distress may not even conceive of the possibility of letting the swamp man get away with his crimes. Rather, the only affordances their attention is directed towards are the various ways one can kill in the game. Either way, the player has to live with the consequences of their decision, and as Amelia Tate reveals in her article, “Red Dead Redemption 2’s rape scene has divided players,” the felt response (*affective involvement*) to this event spanned a wide range of interpretations. Where at one end of the spectrum, some players responded indifferently with “Gayyy,” at the other end players had a far more intense affective response. For some who had personally experienced sexual assault in their past, this event forced them to relive those traumatic experiences bringing the fear, pain, and anxiety with it. Others, however, reported experiencing a profound disorientation, or discomfiture, expressed by one 17-year-old male as making them feel “super uncomfortable” and, ultimately, transforming their perspective on sexual assault:

“‘Yes, it granted me a new perspective on rape,’ says Kyle Rees, 17, from Wales.... ‘Before experiencing this scene I never really gave much thought about rape. I’ve always been a bit negligent or closed-minded about it,’ he admits. ‘I’ve always thought to myself, How can you even allow someone to rape you? Just claw at the dude’s eyes or punch him in the nuts.’ ”

These various attunements, from indifference to discomfiture, demonstrates how attunement expresses the countless modalities of responsiveness to the man-

¹The health core represents the player’s total health, stamina core represents the player’s ability to sprint, and the deadeye core is representative of the player’s ability to slow down time to make combat easier.

ifestation of feedback between game and player. Furthermore, in the case of Kyle mentioned above, this event sparked a realization that many such victims are helpless, even someone as strong and experienced in combat as the game’s protagonist is helpless if totally blindsided. As Sarah Ahmed argues, the sense of comfort, well-being, and satisfaction is a common affect derived from the feeling of fitting in or being at home within a particular environment: we are comfortable when we “*inhabit spaces that extend [our] shape*.” While “we might only notice comfort as an affect when we lose it, when we become uncomfortable” (158), that discomfort affectively discloses our relation to the world in a new way. By removing player control after triggering the cutscene, the game systematically forces the player to accept their own helplessness. In so doing, it disrupts any sense of fittingness and comfort, of belonging to and exerting control over the game world and its inhabitants into one of discomfiture and helplessness by affecting mood, and potentially opinion, through interaction with the game world. In the case of Kyle, this event in *RDR2* affectively discloses to him the world from the position of someone who has experienced sexual assault. Which, upon reflection, evokes a transformation in his being-in-the-world.

To help us break this down further, let’s take Kyle mentioned above as one point of comparison and for the second a hypothetical young child with no concept of rape, sexual assault, or perhaps sex in and of itself. (Though I must note I highly discourage any parent allow their young children to play this game due to its adult content.) Both the child and Kyle are in the same situational circumstance and are exposed to the same stimuli: they are exploring the world and randomly happen on this event. To reiterate, while it is strongly implied that Arthur is raped in this event, there is nothing that definitively supports this thereby allowing for various interpretations. For the young child, it is possible that the metallic-like sounds would be understood as connoting the swamp man rifling through Arthur’s pockets and satchel looking for things to steal which is supported by the fact that Sonny steals 1 dollar from Arthur. Lacking the cultural and contextual knowledge necessary to arrive at the opinion that Arthur is sexually assaulted, the child could viably opine that he was robbed. Given that the game’s narrative and gameplay are centered on being a gang member who participates in various criminal activities, the narrative dimension allows for such an interpretation.

Rockstar has a history of their developers including social commentary in their games; and, this history is but one component of the overall ambient array influencing how we understand and interpret this experience. For instance, as Ian Bogost has observed, *Grand Theft Auto: San Andreas* (2004) requires that the main protagonist, CJ, eat to maintain his stamina. There are few choices of food coming from fast food restaurants. Eating unhealthy foods without going to the gym regularly will result in CJ getting fat and decreasing his ability to sprint for longer distances. Moreover, healthier options are more expensive. Considering CJ’s headquarters are located in a low income area, Bogost argues that this mechanic was an attempt to subtly critique the relative ease and affordability of fast food which partly contributes to higher levels of obesity and poor nutrition in lower income communities. (“Videogames and Ideological

Frames,” 176).

In light of this, some have stipulated that the rape scene in *RDR2* was a developer(s) attempt to challenge victim blaming culture in cases of sexual assault in order to raise awareness in a community that has a notoriously misogynistic history. As Kyle puts it, “I want to believe Rockstar made this scene in order to get people to understand how serious rape cases are.” To reiterate Rickert’s claim, “ambience is rhetorical to the extent that we become a furtherance of or site for rhetorical activity” (120). For Kyle, this event catalyzed a new perspective, it transformed one small element of their being-in-the-world. An effect that is not isolated to the player’s understanding and behavior in the game world, but one that carries over into their existence in the physically real. This player may now actively protest against instances like victim blaming when encountered in online games or gaming communities. In other words, he has become a site for further rhetorical activity. No single element is responsible for the affect this rhetorical event produces; rather, the agency of this event is ambiently dispersed or diffused between various game and player elements over a series of moments which come together to form an ambient whole. The agents include the hardware, programmers, artists, developers, player, NPC, narrative cutscene, the structural and systematic properties of the game and game environment, and more. The combination of which culminate in a *kairotic* moment with the potential to reattune the player’s being-in-the-world. This transformation, ambiently diffused, creates a ripple effect of future rhetorical possibilities with the potential to affect people who never have nor ever will play the game.

By emplacing the player, as a participant, in a virtual rhetorical ecology which actualizes mutual affectability, or feedback, between player and world, a clever developer can leverage ambient rhetoric to reveal the world in a desired way, to reattune or transform the player’s mode of being-in-the-world. That is, a virtual world or event can be rhetorically ontologically transformative only when it affects our for-the-sake-of-which, only when it immerses us in a rhetorical ecology which manifests our relationship to the virtual world not that of subject to depicted object but rather as existing within a relation of mutual affectability. What this particular event demonstrates is how a virtual world can produce—perhaps by intentional design—a transformation in a player’s being-in-the-world by affecting mood and opinion through interaction with the game world. This is achieved by designing a virtual world that takes into account the fundamental nature by which we perceive, understand, and act; in other words, by hacking the human soul.